USDP and the National League for Democracy (NLD), because the proposal was perceived by the NLD as an attempt to undermine its potential for success at the 2015 elections. The amendments to the electoral laws in late 2014 that, among other matters, operated to exclude temporary identity card holders from voting (contrary to past political practise), was one of the darker sides of reform. This change effectively meant that those who hold temporary identity cards (many of whom are Muslim) were unable to vote or run for elections in 2015.

There have been structural reforms in relation to the executive that vests power in the new offices of the president, vice-presidents and ministers. The president's power is wide, and President Thein Sein's (March 2011–March 2016) initiatives have at times been resisted by the parliament. For example, Thein Sein established the Myanmar National Human Rights Commission ('the Commission') by executive order, but when it came time to approve the budget, the parliament refused until the commission was established by law.[8] In addition, Thein Sein has not hesitated to use his power to refer draft bills back to the Union Parliament with suggestions for reform, although under the constitution the Union Parliament has the final say on legislation, with law coming into force fourteen days from assent regardless of the president's opinion.

The legal framework on the administration extends to the newly established self-administered zones, which were born out of the ceasefire deals of the 1990s. These zones are part of the state's strategy to be seen to grant symbolic recognition to select ethnic groups (Crouch 2015b).[9] As Ricky Yue (this volume) notes in relation to the Pa-O Self-Administered Zone, these areas largely exist and function beyond the realm of national law. The reform agenda has also led to laws on local governance, including the administration of Naypyitaw Council, Yangon and Mandalay City Development Council, and the Ward and Village Administration, which is one of the most important administrative units of government at the local level (Chit Saw, Kyi Pyar and Arnold 2014).[10] Overall, power remains concentrated in the central government, although there are persistent calls for greater decentralization of power.

Given the change in legal institutions and authorities, an early law provided that some new institutions replaced existing ones and where legislation mentions these old institutions, it should be taken as referring to the new institution. For example, this 'rebadging' exercise included the replacement of all references in law to the chairperson of the State Peace